‘If you insist on going back to the propulsion team, my conscience would not permit me to deny you that.’ Dhawan was a bit emotional. ‘But if you remain in Trivandrum, that man (Gowarikar) will gobble you up. I will bring you to the headquarters here in Bangalore, as my advisory staff.’

I gave it a serious thought. Dhawan was right. Irrespective of where I worked in VSSC, Gowarikar would victimise me with impunity. Though my heart was in developing the liquid propulsion engine, Dhawan’s offer made sense in more ways than one: I could be away from direct harm from Gowarikar, being in Dhawan’s inner circle came with some advantages—including having some fun at Gowarikar’s expense. I chuckled at the thought.

By making up the furniture corruption story to settle personal scores with me, and later exposing himself to Dhawan, Gowarikar was harming his own chances of rising to the top post of the ISRO chairman. Dhawan never showed anger, but I knew he detested dishonest people. And Gowarikar had painted himself into a corner.

Years later, T N Seshan told me this was one of the incidents that contributed to Dhawan forming a not so flattering opinion about Gowarikar, and later handpicking U R Rao over Gowarikar for the top post. It’s another matter that Rao had all the credentials to be the ISRO chairman, and he proved his mettle, too, but Gowarikar’s Machiavellian ways proved to be his own undoing. I felt no sympathy for his plight when Dhawan passed on the mantle to U R Rao in 1984.

I accepted Dhawan’s offer and joined the headquarters on 29 September 1984. Dhawan surrounded himself with a few of his handpicked men who formed his secretariat. Prominent among them were Siddharth and Y S Rajan. I had known Rajan as the PRL scientist who used to visit Trivandrum on projects. It was using a vacuum pump that Rajan gave that I ran the bell jar experiment that almost killed Kalam.

Siddharth was another icon of efficiency. His questions sounded almost accusative; soon you would realise that it was his style of extracting the exact answer. During relatively free hours I would walk into Siddharth’s room and share our scientific dreams. Siddharth developed a severe skin problem which made him a recluse. He would not meet anyone, but I would still spend time with him, as if he had no such problem. He underwent a rigorous therapy and was cured of the disorder.